A brief goodbye hug.

I said I'd take care of the bill and she said in that case she'd foot the bill for thank-you flowers to Violet.

Peonies, she said.

I laughed. *OK. Bye.*

Goodbye.

Poof, she was gone.

Compared to her, Cinderella was the queen of long goodbyes.

4.

I'D MADE PLANS TO MEET my mate after. Now I phoned him, told him I was on my way, and half an hour later I was barging into his house off the King's Road.

He took one look at my face and said: *What's happened?*

I didn't want to tell him. I kept thinking: Do not tell him. Do not tell him. Do not tell him.

I told him.

I recounted the entire date, then pleaded: *Shit, mate, what am I going to do?*

Out came the tequila. Out came the weed. We drank and smoked and watched…*Inside Out.*

An animated movie…about emotions. Perfect. I was thoroughly inside out.

Then I was peacefully numb. *Good weed, dude.*

My phone rang. *Oh, shit.* I held it up to my mate. *It's her.*

Who?

HER.

She wasn't just calling. She was FaceTiming.

Hello?

Hello.

What are you up to?

Uh, I'm with my mate.

What's that in the background?